



YEDDYURAPPA (LEFT)
INAUGURATING THE
GUNDIYA PROJECT

The Western Ghats rank amongst the 25 biodiversity hot-spots identified in the world. Nearly three decades ago, a proposal to construct a hydroelectric project in Kerala's Silent Valley—which would have submerged the entire biosphere reserve and destroyed its four-million-year-old rainforests—was scrapped after widespread protests. Projects that have faced opposition in Karnataka include the Dandeli Dam proposal on the River Kali which was abandoned four years ago because of the Kali Bachao Andolan in the ecologically sensitive Uttara Kannada district. The state has also seen the GMR power plant being shifted to Andhra Pradesh and the 4,000 MW Nagarjuna project at Tadri being shelved.

"It's not that we are anti-developmental. But developing doesn't mean pillaging. The Gundiya project has not taken into account the economical and social costs involved in destroying a section of the Western Ghats," says Kumar. Scientists studying the Western Ghats at the Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore, have warned the authorities about the fragility of the ecosystem in the region thanks to road and railway projects.

The area of the Gundiya project is home to several thousand plants, animal, fish and insect species. It is hard to imagine the impact on the environment without a detailed and impartial study. A complaint has already been filed by environmental groups objecting to the feasibility of the studies. "We have far too much evidence against the Government and the KPCL; we are confident that the MOEF will never give a clearance to this project and we will go to court if the Government turns a deaf ear to us," says Kumar. The Government and the KPCL are equally confident the project will proceed without much trouble and consider the agitations as minor setbacks. "Development comes at a price", is the oft-quoted answer from the Government. ■

ECOSYSTEM AT STAKE

- Recent studies suggest that of the 4,000 species of flowering plants, 1,500 could be endemic to the Ghats.
- Butterflies in the ghats belong to five families. Thirty species depend on over 1,000 plants for feeding and breeding.
- There are 218 species of primary and secondary freshwater fish, of which 53 per cent are native to the Western Ghats.
- 157 species of reptiles, including crocodiles and snakes, are from here. Of the 508 bird species, 19 are said to be native.

impact of the project on the local people and the environment has not been studied at all," said a protester. The allegation may have some truth if the felling of 80,000 trees in the region is any indication.

Proponents of the project say that Gundiya is a hydroelectric project, which is the cleanest source of energy produced by the massive flow of water to generate electricity without emitting carbon dioxide. According to the Government and the KPCL, the Gundiya project proposes to harness

the availability of a high head besides diverting water from small streams like the Yettinahole and Kerihole to the Hongadahall weir and on to Bettakumbri forebay which is to be built across the Bettakumbri river. "The Government is ready to sacrifice the Western Ghats for a meagre 200 MW of power which is not going to solve any of the state's power problems," rues Kumar. The possibility that the Gundiya project might prove detrimental to the eco-sensitive Western Ghats cannot be ruled out. Besides the destruction of irreplaceable flora and fauna, the project will affect rainfall as well as drinking water availability in Hassan district.

the Western Ghats.